

VIRTUAL REALITY IS THE NEXT BIG THING - What To Look Forward To In 2016



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Virtual reality (VR) is not exactly new, but it seems as though it is only just beginning to enter mainstream. Three major players are set to launch their respective VR products this 2016, with more tech companies to follow suit. After years of building and developing prototypes, consumers will finally have access to an end product that promises to change how they view the world.

Major brands are all aboard

It looks as if all major brands are working on their own VR projects. After Facebook purchased Oculus for US\$ 2 billion back in 2014, more companies have shown interest in what appears to be the next-big computing platform.

Aside from Oculus, Samsung and HTC also managed to create a lot of buzz surrounding their VR headsets. At the recently-concluded Mobile World Congress, Samsung introduced a new addition to their VR line, Gear 360. This 360-degree camera allows users to capture and edit VR-ready videos more conveniently than ever before. It syncs with their Galaxy S7 and S7 Edge smartphones.

With their Gear VR headset, Samsung may prove to be the only brand to offer an end-to-end VR solution to consumers. It has application program interfaces that allow developers to create games and apps, a 360-degree camera

that enables users to generate their own VR content and headset that offers a rich mobile VR experience.

HTC is mostly known for their smartphones, but teaming up with Valve has allowed them to create an outstanding VR headset called Vive. What sets Vive apart from other VR gear is that it comes with full-body tracking. You can respond to calls and texts from your smartphone without having to take off the headset.

The consumer edition is pricier than Oculus Rift. This can be justified by the fact that HTC and Valve want to offer a VR experience in which users stand up and move around, whereas Oculus provides more of a seated experience.

Can consumers afford VR headsets

With such sophisticated technology, it is easy to imagine that the price of VR headsets would be through the roof. This year,

Oculus and HTC announced how much their VR products would cost, finally giving everyone an idea about how much to save if they want to get a piece of these innovative gadgets.

Oculus Rift is priced at US\$ 600, and since it requires a powerful computer, Oculus also offers consumers the option of buying a package consisting of their VR headset and a compatible PC. The combo costs US\$ 1500. HTC Vive, meanwhile, retails at US\$ 799.



*Samsung Gear 360 camera
(Image courtesy: samsung.com)*